Chapter LXXIII

Fatality

SCARCELY had D'Artagnan uttered these words when a ringing and sudden noise was heard resounding through the felucca, which had now become dim in the obscurity of the night.

'That, you may be sure,' said the Gascon, 'means something.'

They then at the same instant perceived a large lantern carried on a pole appear on the deck, defining the forms of shadows behind it.

Suddenly a terrible cry, a cry of despair, was wafted through space; and as if the shrieks of anguish had driven away the clouds, the veil which hid the moon was cleated away and the gray sails and dark shrouds of the felucca were plainly visible beneath the silvery light.

Shadows ran, as if bewildered, to and fro on the vessel, and mournful cries accompanied these delirious walkers. In the midst of these screams they saw Mordaunt upon the poop with a torch in hand.

The agitated figures, apparently wild with terror, consisted of Groslow, who at the hour fixed by Mordaunt had collected his men and the sailors. Mordaunt, after having listened at the door of the cabin to hear if the musketeers were still asleep, had gone down into the cellar, convinced by their silence that they were all in a deep slumber. Then he had run to the train, impetuous as a man who is excited by revenge, and full of confidence, as are those whom God blinds, he had set fire to the wick of nitre.

All this while Groslow and his men were assembled on deck.

'Haul up the cable and draw the boat to us,' said Groslow.

One of the sailors got down the side of the ship, seized the cable, and drew it; it came without the least resistance.

'The cable is cut!' he cried, 'no boat!'

'How! no boat!' exclaimed Groslow; 'it is impossible.'

''Tis true, however,' answered the sailor; 'there's nothing in the wake of the ship; besides, here's the end of the cable.'

'What's the matter?' cried Mordaunt, who, coming up out of the hatchway, rushed to the stern, waving his torch.

'Only that our enemies have escaped; they have cut the cord and gone off with the boat.'

Mordaunt bounded with one step to the cabin and kicked open the door.

'Empty!' he exclaimed; 'the infernal demons!'

'We must pursue them,' said Groslow, 'they can't be gone far, and we will sink them, passing over them.'

'Yes, but the fire,' ejaculated Mordaunt; 'I have lighted it.'

'Ten thousand devils!' cried Groslow, rushing to the hatchway; 'perhaps there is still time to save us.'

Mordaunt answered only by a terrible laugh, threw his torch into the sea and plunged in after it. The instant Groslow put his foot upon the hatchway steps the ship opened like the crater of a volcano. A burst of flame rose toward the skies with an explosion like that of a hundred cannon; the air burned, ignited by flaming embers, then the frightful lightning disappeared, the brands sank, one after another, into the abyss, where they were extinguished, and save for a slight vibration in the air, after a few minutes had elapsed one would have thought that nothing had happened.

Only—the felucca had disappeared from the surface of the sea and Groslow and his three sailors were consumed.

The four friends saw all this—not a single detail of this fearful scene escaped them. At one moment, bathed as they were in a flood of brilliant light, which illumined the sea for the space of a league, they might each be seen, each by his own peculiar attitude and manner expressing the awe which, even in their hearts of bronze, they could not help experiencing. Soon a torrent of vivid sparks fell around them—then, at last, the volcano was extinguished—then all was dark and still—the floating bark and heaving ocean.

They sat silent and dejected.

'By Heaven!' at last said Athos, the first to speak, 'by this time, I think, all must be over.'

'Ah! have you your sword, Athos?' cried D'Artagnan.

'Yes.'

'Cut the cable, then.'

Athos drew a sharp poniard from his belt and cut the cord. The felucca went on, the boat continued stationary, rocked only by the swashing waves.

'Come, Athos!' said D'Artagnan, giving his hand to the count; 'you are going to see something curious,' added the Gascon.

'When people can swim at all they can swim anywhere. To the boat! to the boat!'

'But Porthos, I do not see him.'

'Porthos is coming—he swims like Leviathan.'

In fact, Porthos did not appear; for a scene, half tragedy and half comedy, had been performed by him with Mousqueton and Blaisois, who, frightened by the noise of the sea, by the whistling of the wind, by the sight of that dark water yawning like a gulf beneath them, shrank back instead of going forward.

'Come, come!' said Porthos; 'jump in.'

'But, monsieur,' said Mousqueton, 'I can't swim; let me stay here.'

'And me, too, monsieur,' said Blaisois.

'I assure you, I shall be very much in the way in that little boat,' said Mousqueton.

'And I know I shall drown before reaching it,' continued Blaisois.

'Come along! I shall strangle you both if you don't get out,' said Porthos at last, seizing Mousqueton by the throat. 'Forward, Blaisois!'

A groan, stifled by the grasp of Porthos, was all the reply of poor Blaisois, for the giant, taking him neck and heels, plunged him into the water headforemost, pushing him out of the window as if he had been a plank.

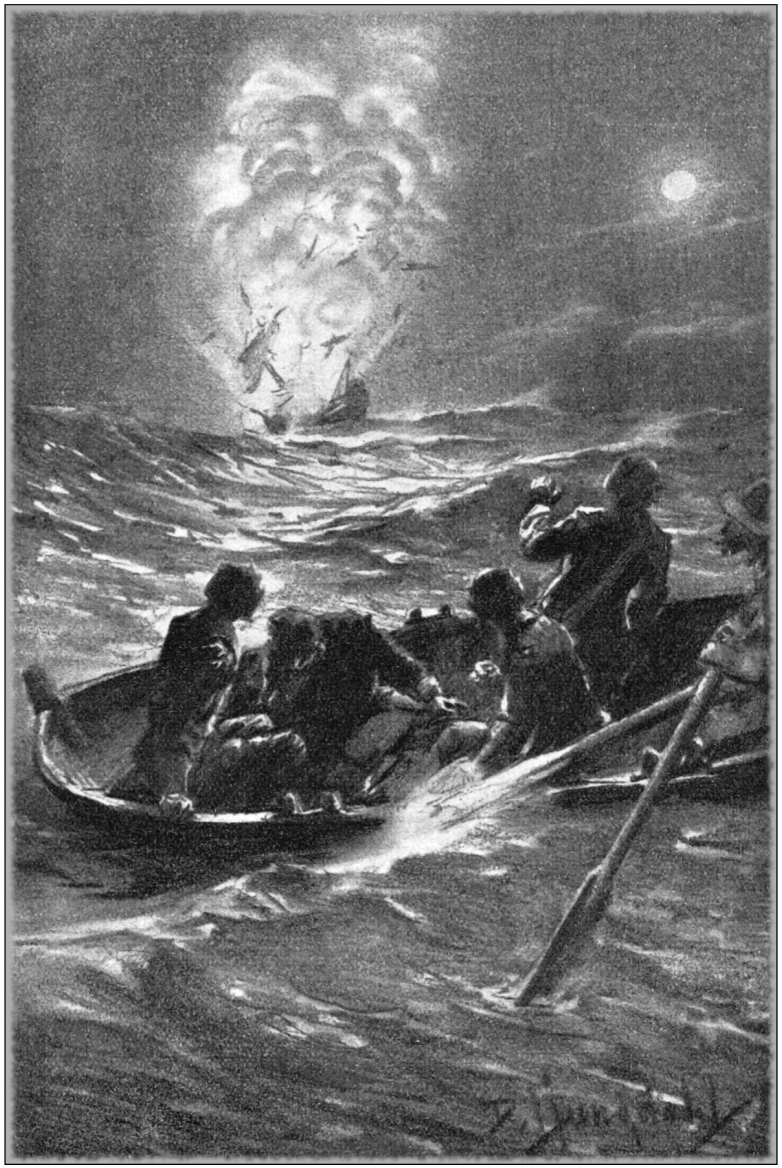
'Now, Mousqueton,' he said, 'I hope you don't mean to desert your master?'

'Ah, sir,' replied Mousqueton, his eyes filling with tears, 'why did you re-enter the army? We were all so happy in the Château de Pierrefonds!'

And without any other complaint, passive and obedient, either from true devotion to his master or from the example set by Blaisois, Mousqueton leaped into the sea headforemost. A sublime action, at all events, for Mousqueton looked upon himself as dead. But Porthos was not a man to abandon an old servant, and when Mousqueton rose above the water, blind as a new-born puppy, he found he was supported by the large hand of Porthos and that he was thus enabled, without having occasion even to move, to advance toward the cable with the dignity of a very triton.

In a few minutes Porthos had rejoined his companions, who were already in the boat; but when, after they had all got in, it came to his turn, there was great danger that in putting his huge leg over the edge of the boat he would upset the little vessel. Athos was the last to enter.

'Are you all here?' he asked.



The ship opened like the crater of a volcano

'Here, my lords! save me! help!' cried a voice, whose mournful accents, reaching the four friends, seemed to proceed from some phantom of the ocean.

All looked around; Athos himself stared.

''Tis he! it is his voice!'

All still remained silent, the eyes of all were turned in the direction where the vessel had disappeared, endeavouring in vain to penetrate the darkness. After a minute or two they were able to distinguish a man, who approached them, swimming vigorously.

Athos extended his arm toward him, pointing him out to his companions.

'Yes, yes, I see him well enough,' said D'Artagnan.

'He—again!' cried Porthos, who was breathing like a blacksmith's bellows; 'why, he is made of iron.'

'Oh, my God!' muttered Athos.

Aramis and D'Artagnan whispered to each other.

Mordaunt made several strokes more, and raising his arm in sign of distress above the waves: 'Pity, pity on me, gentlemen, in Heaven's name! my strength is failing me; I am dying.'

The voice that implored aid was so piteous that it awakened pity in the heart of Athos.

'Poor fellow!' he exclaimed.

'Indeed!' said D'Artagnan, 'monsters have only to complain to gain your sympathy. I believe he's swimming toward us. Does he think we are going to take him in? Row, Porthos, row.' And setting the example he plowed his oar into the sea; two strokes took the bark on twenty fathoms further.

'Oh! you will not abandon me! You will not leave me to perish! You will not be pitiless!' cried Mordaunt.

'Ah! ah!' said Porthos to Mordaunt, 'I think we have you now, my hero! and there are no doors by which you can escape this time but those of hell.'

'Oh! Porthos!' murmured the Comte de la Fère.

'Oh, pray, for mercy's sake, don't fly from me. For pity's sake!' cried the young man, whose agony-drawn breath at times, when his head went under water, under the wave, exhaled and made the icy waters bubble.

D'Artagnan, however, who had consulted with Aramis, spoke to the poor wretch. 'Go away,' he said; 'your repentance is too recent to inspire confidence. See! the vessel in which you wished to fry us is still smoking; and the situation

'The deuce! it is a very cold one, my dear friend,' said Aramis.

'Stay here, if you like, but I warn you 'twill be rather too warm presently.'

'But we cannot swim to the shore.'

'The longboat is yonder, lashed to the felucca. We will take possession of it and cut the cable. Come, my friends.'

'A moment's delay,' said Athos; 'our servants?'

'Here we are!' they cried.

Meantime the three friends were standing motionless before the awful sight which D'Artagnan, in raising the shutters, had disclosed to them through the narrow opening of the window.

Those who have once beheld such a spectacle know that there is nothing more solemn, more striking, than the raging sea, rolling, with its deafening roar, its dark billows beneath the pale light of a wintry moon.

'Gracious Heaven, we are hesitating!' cried D'Artagnan; 'if we hesitate what will the servants do?'

'I do not hesitate, you know,' said Grimaud.

'Sir,' interposed Blaisois, 'I warn you that I can only swim in rivers.'

'And I not at all,' said Mousqueton.

But D'Artagnan had now slipped through the window.

'You have decided, friend?' said Athos.

'Yes,' the Gascon answered; 'Athos! you, who are a perfect being, bid spirit triumph over body. Do you, Aramis, order the servants. Porthos, kill every one who stands in your way.'

And after pressing the hand of Athos, D'Artagnan chose a moment when the ship rolled backward, so that he had only to plunge into the water, which was already up to his waist.

Athos followed him before the felucca rose again on the waves; the cable which tied the boat to the vessel was then seen plainly rising out of the sea.

D'Artagnan swam to it and held it, suspending himself by this rope, his head alone out of water.

In one second Athos joined him.

Then they saw, as the felucca turned, two other heads peeping, those of Aramis and Grimaud.

'I am uneasy about Blaisois,' said Athos; 'he can, he says, only swim in rivers.'

'Bah!' said Athos, 'are you still afraid?'

'Do you know who is captain of this vessel?'

'No.'

'Captain Groslow.'

The shudder of the three musketeers showed to D'Artagnan that his words began to make some impression on them.

'Groslow!' said Aramis; "the devil!

'Who is this Groslow?' asked Porthos. 'I don't remember him.'

'Groslow is the man who broke Parry's head and is now getting ready to break ours.'

'Oh! oh!'

'And do you know who is his lieutenant?'

'His lieutenant? There is none,' said Athos. 'They don't have lieutenants in a felucca manned by a crew of four.'

'Yes, but Monsieur Groslow is not a captain of the ordinary kind; he has a lieutenant, and that lieutenant is Monsieur Mordaunt.'

This time the musketeers did more than shudder—they almost cried out. Those invincible men were subject to a mysterious and fatal influence which that name had over them; the mere sound of it filled them with terror.

'What shall we do?' said Athos.

'We must seize the felucca,' said Aramis.

'And kill him,' said Porthos.

'The felucca is mined,' said D'Artagnan. 'Those casks which I took for casks of port wine are filled with powder. When Mordaunt finds himself discovered he will destroy all, friends and foes; and on my word he would be bad company in going either to Heaven or to hell.'

'You have some plan, then?' asked Athos.

'Yes.'

'What is it?'

'Have you confidence in me?'

'Give your orders,' said the three musketeers.

'Very well; come this way.'

D'Artagnan went toward a very small, low window, just large enough to let a man through. He turned it gently on its hinges.

'There,' he said, 'is our road.'

in which you are is a bed of roses compared to that in which you wished to place us and in which you have placed Monsieur Groslow and his companions.'

'Sir!' replied Mordaunt, in a tone of deep despair, 'my penitence is sincere. Gentlemen, I am young, scarcely twenty-three years old. I was drawn on by a very natural resentment to avenge my mother. You would have done what I did.'

Mordaunt wanted now only two or three fathoms to reach the boat, for the approach of death seemed to give him supernatural strength.

'Alas!' he said, 'I am then to die? You are going to kill the son, as you killed the mother! Surely, if I am culpable and if I ask for pardon, I ought to be forgiven.'

Then, as if his strength failed him, he seemed unable to sustain himself above the water and a wave passed over his head, which drowned his voice.

'Oh! this is torture to me,' cried Athos.

Mordaunt reappeared.

'For my part,' said D'Artagnan, 'I say this must come to an end; murderer, as you were, of your uncle! executioner, as you were, of King Charles! incendiary! I recommend you to sink forthwith to the bottom of the sea; and if you come another fathom nearer, I'll stave your wicked head in with this oar.'

'D'Artagnan! D'Artagnan!' cried Athos, 'my son, I entreat you; the wretch is dying, and it is horrible to let a man die without extending a hand to save him. I cannot resist doing so; he must live.'

'Zounds!' replied D'Artagnan, 'why don't you give yourself up directly, feet and hands bound, to that wretch? Ah! Comte de la Fère, you wish to perish by his hands! I, your son, as you call me—I will not let you!'

'Twas the first time D'Artagnan had ever refused a request from Athos.

Aramis calmly drew his sword, which he had carried between his teeth as he swam.

'If he lays his hand on the boat's edge I will cut it off, regicide that he is.'

'And I,' said Porthos. 'Wait.'

'What are you going to do?' asked Aramis.

'Throw myself in the water and strangle him.'

'Oh, gentlemen!' cried Athos, 'be men! be Christians! See! death is depicted on his face! Ah! do not bring on me the horrors of remorse! Grant me this poor wretch's life. I will bless you—I— '

'I am dying!' cried Mordaunt, 'come to me! come to me!'

D'Artagnan began to be touched. The boat at this moment turned around, and the dying man was by that turn brought nearer Athos.

'Monsieur the Comte de la Fère,' he cried, 'I supplicate you! pity me! I call on you—where are you? I see you no longer—I am dying—help me! help me!'

'Here I am, sir!' said Athos, leaning and stretching out his arm to Mordaunt with that air of dignity and nobility of soul habitual to him; 'here I am, take my hand and jump into our boat.'

Mordaunt made a last effort—rose—seized the hand thus extended to him and grasped it with the vehemence of despair.

'That's right,' said Athos; 'put your other hand here.' And he offered him his shoulder as another stay and support, so that his head almost touched that of Mordaunt; and these two mortal enemies were in as close an embrace as if they had been brothers.

'Now, sir,' said the count, 'you are safe—calm yourself.'

'Ah! my mother,' cried Mordaunt, with eyes on fire with a look of hate impossible to paint, 'I can only offer thee one victim, but it shall at any rate be the one thou wouldst thyself have chosen!'

And whilst D'Artagnan uttered a cry, Porthos raised the oar, and Aramis sought a place to strike, a frightful shake given to the boat precipitated Athos into the sea; whilst Mordaunt, with a shout of triumph, grasped the neck of his victim, and in order to paralyse his movements, twined arms and legs around the musketeer. For an instant, without an exclamation, without a cry for help, Athos tried to sustain himself on the surface of the waters, but the weight dragged him down; he disappeared by degrees; soon nothing was to be seen except his long, floating hair; then both men disappeared and the bubbling of the water, which, in its turn, was soon effaced, alone indicated the spot where these two had sunk.

Mute with horror, the three friends had remained open-mouthed, their eyes dilated, their arms extended like statues, and, motionless as they were, the beating of their hearts was audible. Porthos was the first who came to himself. He tore his hair.

'Oh!' he cried, 'Athos! Athos! thou man of noble heart; woe is me! I have let thee perish!'

Chapter LXXII

End of the Port Wine Mystery

GRIMAUD waited till he heard the bolt grind in the lock and when he was satisfied that he was alone he slowly rose from his recumbent posture.

'Ah!' he said, wiping with his sleeve large drops of sweat from his forehead, 'how lucky it was that Mousqueton was thirsty!'

He made haste to pass out by the opening, still thinking himself in a dream; but the sight of the gunpowder in the tankard proved to him that his dream was a fatal nightmare.

It may be imagined that D'Artagnan listened to these details with increasing interest; before Grimaud had finished he rose without noise and putting his mouth to Aramis's ear, and at the same time touching him on the shoulder to prevent a sudden movement:

'Chevalier,' he said, 'get up and don't make the least noise.'

Aramis awoke. D'Artagnan, pressing his hand, repeated his call. Aramis obeyed.

'Athos is near you,' said D'Artagnan; 'warn him as I have warned you.'

Aramis easily aroused Athos, whose sleep was light, like that of all persons of a finely organised constitution. But there was more difficulty in arousing Porthos. He was beginning to ask full explanation of that breaking in on his sleep, which was very annoying to him, when D'Artagnan, instead of explaining, closed his mouth with his hand.

Then our Gascon, extending his arms, drew to him the heads of his three friends till they almost touched one another.

'Friends,' he said, 'we must leave this craft at once or we are dead men.'

At this instant, in the midst of the silver circle illumined by the light of the moon the same whirlpool which had been made by the sinking men was again obvious, and first were seen, rising above the waves, a wisp of hair, then a pale face with open eyes, yet, nevertheless, the eyes of death; then a body, which, after rising of itself even to the waist above the sea, turned gently on its back, according to the caprice of the waves, and floated.

In the bosom of this corpse was plunged a poniard, the gold hilt of which shone in the moonbeams.

'Mordaunt! Mordaunt!' cried the three friends; ''tis Mordaunt!'

'But Athos!' exclaimed D'Artagnan.

Suddenly the boat leaned on one side beneath a new and unexpected weight and Grimaud uttered a shout of joy; every one turned around and beheld Athos, livid, his eyes dim and his hands trembling, supporting himself on the edge of the boat. Eight vigorous arms lifted him up immediately and laid him in the boat, where directly Athos was warmed and reanimated, reviving with the caresses and cares of his friends, who were intoxicated with joy.

'You are not hurt?' asked D'Artagnan.

'No,' replied Athos; 'and he— '

'Oh, he! now we may say at last, thank Heaven! he is really dead. Look!' and D'Artagnan, obliging Athos to look in the direction he pointed, showed him the body of Mordaunt floating on its back, which, sometimes submerged, sometimes rising, seemed still to pursue the four friends with looks of insult and mortal hatred.

At last he sank. Athos had followed him with a glance in which the deepest melancholy and pity were expressed.

'Bravo! Athos!' cried Aramis, with an emotion very rare in him.

'A capital blow you gave!' cried Porthos.

'I have a *son*. I wished to live,' said Athos.

'In short,' said D'Artagnan, 'this has been the will of God.'

'It was not I who killed him,' said Athos in a soft, low tone, ''twas destiny.'

'I understand all perfectly, sir,' replied Groslow; 'but allow me to say there is great danger in what you undertake; would it not be better to intrust one of the men to set fire to the train?'

'My dear Groslow,' answered Mordaunt, 'you know the French proverb, "Nothing one does not do one's self is ever well done." I shall abide by that rule.'

Grimaud had heard all this, if he had not understood it. But what he saw made good what he lacked in perfect comprehension of the language. He had seen the two mortal enemies of the musketeers, had seen Mordaunt adjust the fuse; he had heard the proverb, which Mordaunt had given in French. Then he felt and felt again the contents of the tankard he held in his hand; and, instead of the lively liquor expected by Blaisois and Mousqueton, he found beneath his fingers the grains of some coarse powder.

Mordaunt went away with the captain. At the door he stopped to listen.

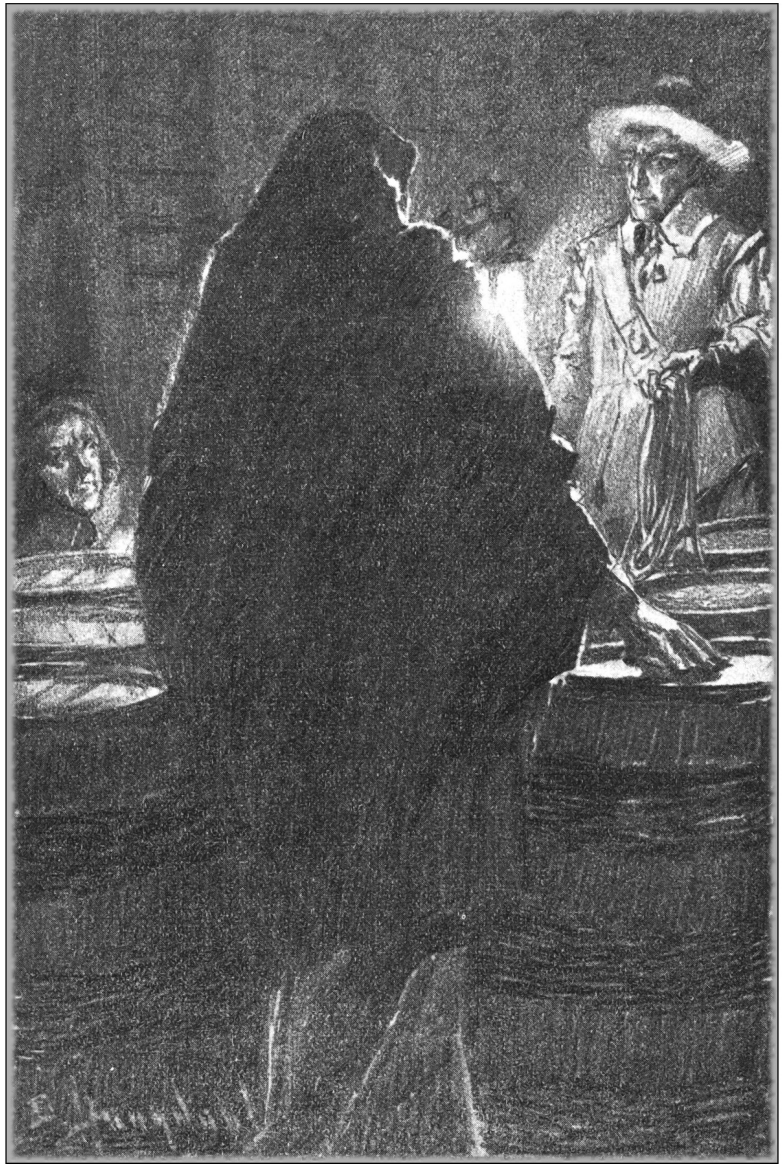
'Do you hear how they sleep?' he asked.

In fact, Porthos could be heard snoring through the partition.

''Tis God who gives them into our hands,' answered Groslow.

'This time the devil himself shall not save them,' rejoined Mordaunt.

And they went out together.



'Have you the wick?'

Chapter LXXIV

How Mousqueton had a Narrow Escape of Being Eaten

A deep silence reigned for a long time in the boat after the fearful scene described.

The moon, which had shone for a short time, disappeared behind the clouds; every object was again plunged in the obscurity that is so awful in the deserts and still more so in that liquid desert, the ocean, and nothing was heard save the whistling of the west wind driving along the tops of the crested billows.

Porthos was the first to speak.

'I have seen,' he said, 'many dreadful things, but nothing that ever agitated me so much as what I have just witnessed. Nevertheless, even in my present state of perturbation, I protest that I feel happy. I have a hundred pounds' weight less upon my chest. I breathe more freely.' In fact, Porthos breathed so loud as to do credit to the free play of his powerful lungs.

'For my part,' observed Aramis, 'I cannot say the same as you do, Porthos. I am still terrified to such a degree that I scarcely believe my eyes. I look around the boat, expecting every moment to see that poor wretch holding between his hands the poniard plunged into his heart.'

'Oh! I feel easy,' replied Porthos. 'The poniard was pointed at the sixth rib and buried up to the hilt in his body. I do not reproach you, Athos, for what you have done. On the contrary, when one aims a blow that is the regulation way to strike. So now, I breathe again—I am happy!'

'Don't be in haste to celebrate a victory, Porthos,' interposed D'Artagnan; 'never have we incurred a greater danger than we are now encountering. Men

may subdue men—they cannot overcome the elements. We are now on the sea, at night, without any pilot, in a frail bark; should a blast of wind upset the boat we are lost.'

Mousqueton heaved a deep sigh.

'You are ungrateful, D'Artagnan,' said Athos; 'yes, ungrateful to Providence, to whom we owe our safety in the most miraculous manner. Let us sail before the wind, and unless it changes we shall be drifted either to Calais or Boulogne. Should our bark be upset we are five of us good swimmers, able enough to turn it over again, or if not, to hold on by it. Now we are on the very road which all the vessels between Dover and Calais take, 'tis impossible but that we should meet with a fisherman who will pick us up.'

'But should we not find any fisherman and should the wind shift to the north?'

'That,' said Athos, 'would be quite another thing; and we should nevermore see land until we were upon the other side of the Atlantic.'

'Which implies that we may die of hunger,' said Aramis.

''Tis more than possible,' answered the Comte de la Fère.

Mousqueton sighed again, more deeply than before.

'What is the matter? what ails you?' asked Porthos.

'I am cold, sir,' said Mousqueton.

'Impossible! your body is covered with a coating of fat which preserves it from the cold air.'

'Ah! sir, 'tis this very coating of fat that makes me shiver.'

'How is that, Mousqueton?'

'Alas! your honour, in the library of the Château of Bracieux there are a lot of books of travels.'

'What then?'

'Amongst them the voyages of Jean Mocquet in the time of Henry IV'

'Well?'

'In these books, your honour, 'tis told how hungry voyagers, drifting out to sea, have a bad habit of eating each other and beginning with— '

'The fattest among them!' cried D'Artagnan, unable in spite of the gravity of the occasion to help laughing.

Whilst he was thinking that he should first taste the liquor which the tankard contained before taking it to his companions, the door of the cellar opened and a man with a lantern in his hands and enveloped in a cloak, came and stood just before the hogshead, behind which Grimaud, on hearing him come in, instantly crept. This was Groslow. He was accompanied by another man, who carried in his hand something long and flexible rolled up, resembling a washing line. His face was hidden under the wide brim of his hat. Grimaud, thinking that they had come, as he had, to try the port wine, effaced himself behind his cask and consoled himself with the reflection that if he were discovered the crime was not a great one.

'Have you the wick?' asked the one who carried the lantern.

'Here it is,' answered the other.

At the voice of this last speaker, Grimaud started and felt a shudder creeping through his very marrow. He rose gently, so that his head was just above the round of the barrel, and under the large hat he recognised the pale face of Mordaunt.

'How long will this fuse burn?' asked this person.

'About five minutes,' replied the captain.

That voice also was known to Grimaud. He looked from one to the other and after Mordaunt he recognised Groslow.

'Then tell the men to be in readiness—don't tell them why now. When the clock strikes a quarter after midnight collect your men. Get down into the longboat.'

'That is, when I have lighted the match?'

'I will undertake that. I wish to be sure of my revenge. Are the oars in the boat?'

'Everything is ready.'

''Tis well.'

Mordaunt knelt down and fastened one end of the train to the spigot, in order that he might have nothing to do but to set it on fire at the opposite end with the match.

He then arose.

'You hear me—at a quarter past midnight—in fact, in twenty minutes.'